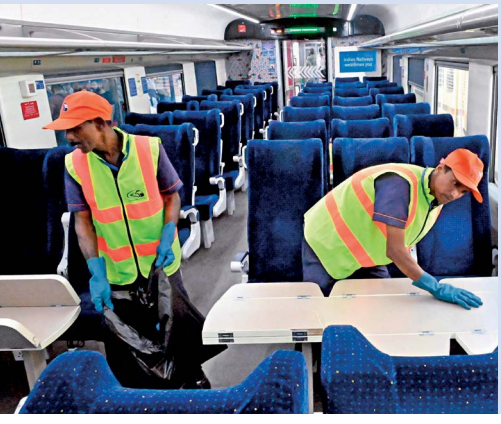


THE PLAINT: Passengers wanted softer seats in a more pleasant shade, subdued lights and better cooling

THE FIX: Seats are now a deep blue instead of bright red, 25% softer and recline more (19 degrees); thicker window blinds to keep out the sun. Rubber panels added to bolster AC cooling

THE PLAINT: Vande Bharat's turnaround time was still lagging

THE FIX: '14-minute miracle cleaning' drill launched to reduce turnaround time of coaches



ANI



ANI

THE PLAINT: Stone-pelting and stray cattle on tracks still a huge problem. Vande Bharat windows have been shattered 283 times so far

THE FIX: 151 people arrested for stone pelting; RPF launches 'Operation Saathi' to reach out to settlements along rail routes. For stray cattle problem, tracks being fenced in vulnerable areas in Gujarat and UP

THE PLAINT: Sleeper version of Vande Bharats needed for long distance, 1,000-plus km journeys

THE FIX: Prototype of sleeper version will be ready by early 2024

REVAMPED STATIONS, STRONGER TRACKS, NEW CONNECTIVITY PROJECTS... THE MODI GOVT HAS PUT ITS MONEY ON THE VANDE BHARAT CLASS OF TRAINS TO OVERHAUL INDIA'S ARCHAIC RAIL SYSTEM

puram division of Southern Railway.

Another problem the semi-high-speed trains face is that India's old tracks are littered with "speed restrictions" imposed due to engineering challenges like curvature and weaker track beds. That's why the Vande Bharats hit their 160 kmph top speed only on some stretches. Instructions have gone out to all zonal railways to work on track infrastructure on priority so that all trains can increase their average speeds.

BOVINES ETC.

The two constant spoilers in the Vande Bharat record since the start have been stray cattle and stone-pelting. Every stone-pelting incident rattles local railway administrations, which then launch investigations with the state police. Data shows 151 people have been arrested for the offence. Vaishnaw told the Lok Sabha in the last monsoon session that replacing the broken windows has cost the railways Rs 55 lakh since 2019. For what it's worth, the Railway Protection Force as well as the Government Railway Police have now started 'Operation Saathi', reaching out to settlements along the Vande Bharat routes where there have been incidents, to 'counsel' people. For the stray cattle problem, work was sanctioned to construct fences along the routes in Gujarat and Uttar Pradesh. New designs of fencing, including those inspired by crash barriers along the national highways, were approved. Cattle-related incidents have now come down drastically.

BETTING BIG

All this focus on a single train type is because the Modi government has put all its money on the Vande Bharat class of trains to overhaul India's archaic rail system. This is the only new train with a definite technology upgrade introduced during this government's tenure.

That's why the 2022 Union Budget announced 400 more Vande Bharats over the next three years, over and above the 104 sanctioned already. The government's push on infrastructure, with a lavish outlay of Rs 10 lakh crore this year, includes pumping a quarter of that amount into upgrading the old rail system through modern trains, revamped stations, stronger tracks and new connectivity projects. The Vande Bharat is at the centre of this vision.

By March 2024, around 75 of the current chair-car variant of the Vande Bharats will roll out. Beyond that, the focus is on manufacturing only sleeper versions, for long-distance journeys of 1,000-plus km, like the Rajdhanis and other superfast trains. "With the sleeper Vande Bharats, sectors like Delhi to Kolkata will become overnight journeys. Take the train at 10 pm in the night in Delhi and reach Kolkata by, say, 8 in the morning," says Vaishnaw.

For shorter, intercity commutes, less than 500 km, there will be eight-coach Vande Metros, to be launched by November-December this year. "The metro versions will have all the specs and features of existing Vande Bharats. A prototype of the sleeper version will be ready by early next year," says B.G. Mallya, general manager at the Integral Coach Factory (ICF), Chennai.

Industry has been roped in to aid the